

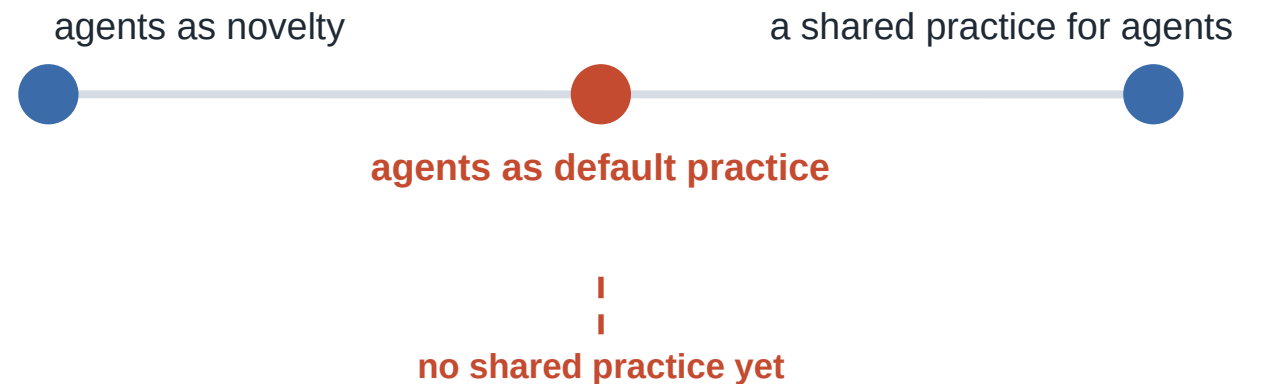
# One document discipline governs agent work from intent to release

An evaluation briefing for engineering leaders whose teams build with AI agents



## 2 Agents now write most production code without a shared practice

- Most professional developers ship agent-written code every day
- The output is locally good and globally inconsistent
- The document disciplines human teams built never reached the agents
- Every practice era gets its equivalent of test-driven development



how agent-written code became the default before any discipline caught up

# 3 Without that practice, agent code drifts from its governing documents

- Specs, designs, and tests fall out of sync because nobody walks them between sessions
- A feature ships whose design contradicts a decision recorded months earlier
- Each new conversation re-improvises the workflow, so reviews that should happen do not

1

## Drift

specs and code  
diverge between  
sessions

2

## Contradiction

a design ignores an  
earlier decision

3

## Lost context

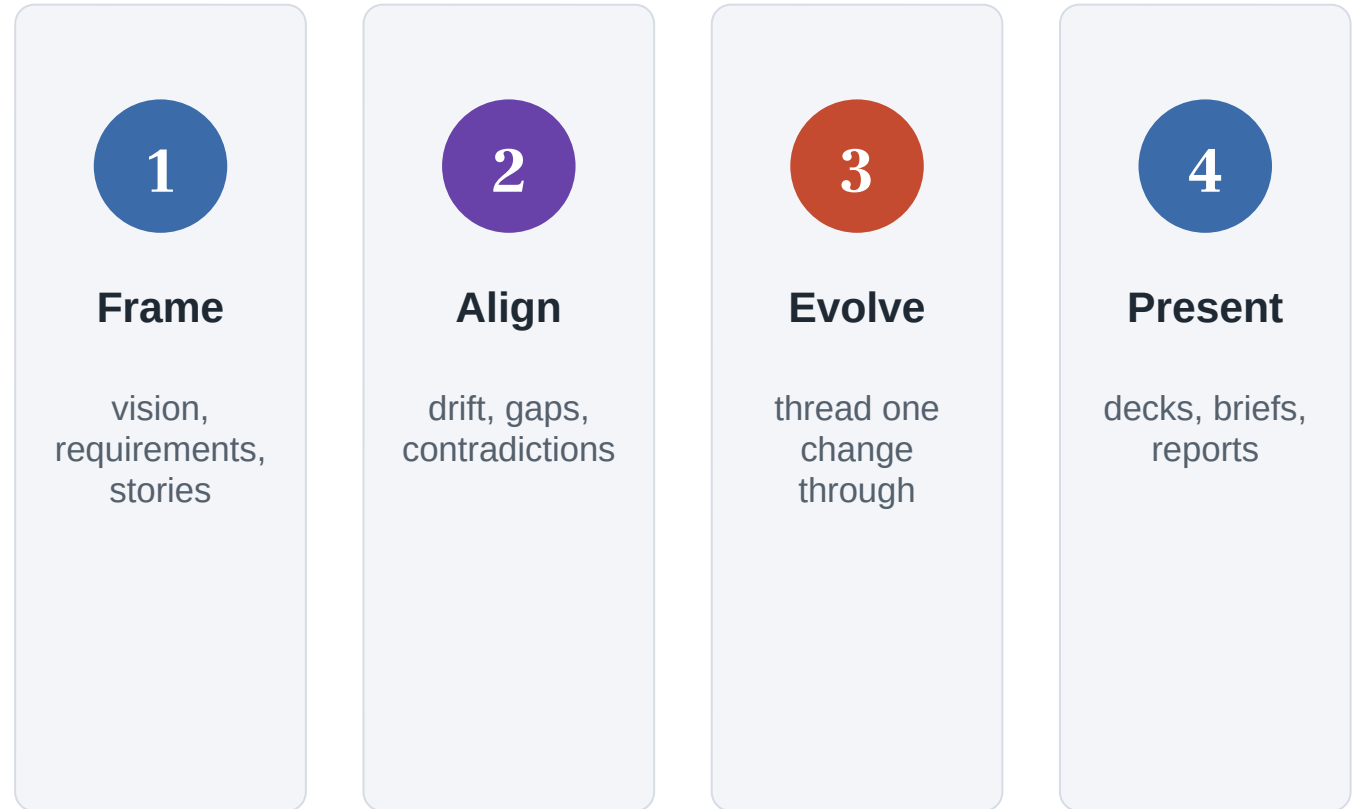
every session starts  
from zero

## 4 HELIX answers with 53 document templates across a seven-activity loop

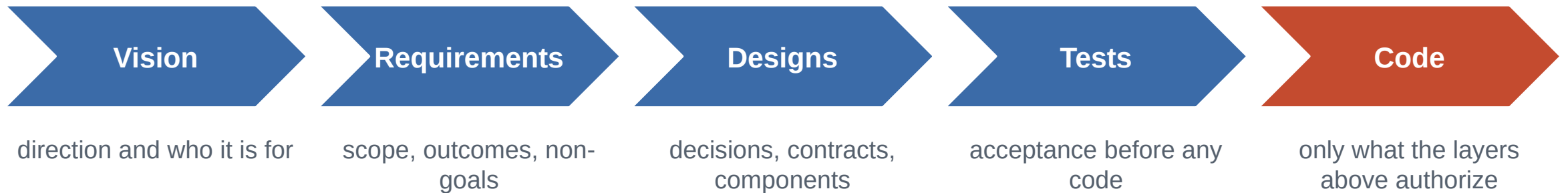
| Activity | What the templates produce                                         |
|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Discover | vision, business case, market and competitive analysis             |
| Frame    | requirements, features, user stories, concerns, principles         |
| Design   | architecture, decisions, contracts, solution and technical designs |
| Test     | test plans and quality expectations, written before code           |
| Build    | implementation plans against those tests                           |
| Deploy   | checklists, runbooks, monitoring, release notes                    |
| Iterate  | metrics, backlog, iteration plans, status reports, deliverables    |

## 5 One skill routes twenty-one modes over those documents

- A single skill installs on the agent runtime and reads the same documents
- It routes each request to one mode: frame, align, evolve, review, present, and more
- Alignment is the required mode; it finds drift and hands back a plan
- The skill body is portable: no runtime commands, so it loads on any host



## 6 Each document layer governs the next, from vision down to code



**a change enters at the top layer it touches and flows down**

# 7 Concerns and gates carry that control across every layer

## Without layered control

Each agent re-decides framework, auth, and test approach per task

Drift shows up in review or in production

A claim of done goes unchecked

## With layered control

- ✓ The team selects a concern once and its practices propagate down
- ✓ Gates stop work moving down a layer
- ✓ Every claim cites evidence a validator can check

**Verdict: the rules live in the layers, not in a prompt**

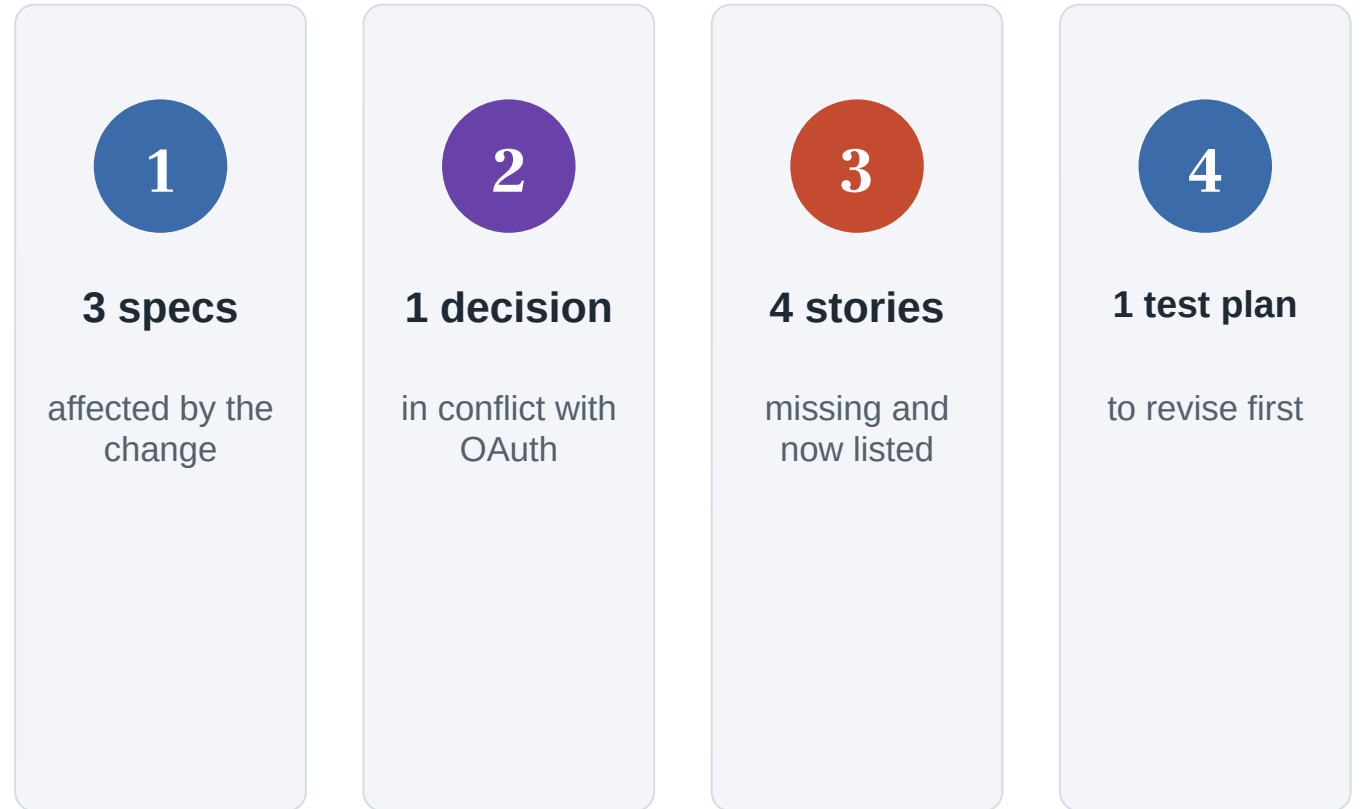
## 8 Every layer also yields documents people outside engineering read

| Output        | Who reads it             | Comes from                                      |
|---------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Status report | sponsors and clients     | the iteration plan, evidence per claim          |
| Deck or brief | executives and customers | any governed document set, every number sourced |
| Release notes | users and support        | the deploy documents                            |



## 9 One alignment gate caught three drifted documents before anyone coded

- A team asked its agent to add OAuth login
- The alignment check found 3 affected feature specs and 2 affected designs
- It flagged 1 recorded decision that conflicted with the OAuth pattern
- It listed 4 missing user stories and 1 test plan to revise



10

# At every gate a person decides and an agent drafts

## People hold

- ✓ What to build and which decision stands
- ✓ Approval that turns a draft into authority
- ✓ When the work is complete
- ✓ How much runs unasked, a three-position dial

## Agents hold

- Drafting every document in its template
- Checking each draft against the layer above
- Surfacing drift, contradictions, and gaps
- Stopping at the triggers and handing judgment back

**Verdict: the hand-offs have owners and rules, never an implied one**

# 11 Pilot HELIX for one quarter and count what each gate catches

## Pilot HELIX for one quarter and count what each gate catches

|   | Step                                                                                        | Owner | Date  |
|---|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|-------|
| 1 | Pick one active project with an agent already in the loop, by the end of this week          | _____ | _____ |
| 2 | Adopt the templates and run one alignment check on its documents in the first sprint        | _____ | _____ |
| 3 | Review the findings together after four weeks against the bar of under 3 findings per check | _____ | _____ |

Without a trial the practice stays improvised and drift keeps surfacing in review

# Sources

| Id | Claim or figure                                                                                  | Governing artifact and section                                                                                 |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| S1 | A methodology and artifact catalog for AI-assisted teams: templates plus one skill               | docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#mission-statement                                                     |
| S2 | AI-assisted development went from novelty to default; most developers ship AI-touched code daily | docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#why-now                                                               |
| S3 | Three failure modes: artifact drift, inconsistent agent behavior, lossy session boundaries       | docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#problem                                                                             |
| S4 | Templates for 53 artifact types plus a single routing skill; no CLI, tracker, or execution loop  | docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#summary                                                                             |
| S5 | The seven activities, the artifact loop, and the authority hierarchy                             | workflows/README.md#activities,<br>workflows/README.md#authority-hierarchy,<br>workflows/artifact-hierarchy.md |

# Sources (continued)

| Id  | Claim or figure                                                                                              | Governing artifact and section                                                                 |
|-----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| S6  | Twenty-one routed modes in the routing table; alignment is the required mode                                 | skills/helix/SKILL.md#routing-rules, docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#goals                          |
| S7  | Four-step contract: write the brief, check alignment, plan the work, run it                                  | docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#core-workflow-contract                                              |
| S8  | OAuth example: three specs and two designs affected, one decision in conflict, four stories missing          | docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#user-experience                                       |
| S9  | Concerns propagate practices downstream; the project's active concerns and slots; 50 concerns in the library | workflows/README.md#cross-cutting-context, docs/helix/01-frame/concerns.md, workflows/concerns |
| S10 | Seven principles, from spec is the contract to deliverable over machinery, with tension resolution           | workflows/principles.md#principles, docs/helix/01-frame/principles.md                          |

# Sources (continued)

| Id  | Claim or figure                                                                                 | Governing artifact and section                                                                             |
|-----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| S11 | Artifact honesty: phantom claims block; verification evidence comes from the running system     | docs/helix/01-frame/features/FEAT-016-artifact-honesty.md,<br>workflows/concerns/verification/practices.md |
| S12 | Tests cite the criterion they cover; quality floors never slide back                            | docs/helix/02-design/adr/ADR-009-acceptance-criteria-ownership.md, workflows/ratchets.md                   |
| S13 | Non-goals: no CLI, tracker, queue, or engine; no imposed technology; judgment stays with people | docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#non-goals                                                                       |
| S14 | Six install surfaces: DDx, Claude Code, Codex, Copilot, Databricks Genie, Grok Build            | docs/helix/01-frame/features/FEAT-013-runtime-install-coverage.md, docs/install/README.md                  |
| S15 | Autonomy is a three-position spectrum with a hard-stop floor at every level                     | docs/helix/02-design/adr/ADR-003-autonomy-spectrum.md                                                      |

# Sources (continued)

| Id  | Claim or figure                                                                                                                       | Governing artifact and section                                                                          |
|-----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| S16 | Roadmap, iteration plan, status report; a client cut may subset but never contradict                                                  | docs/helix/01-frame/features/FEAT-017-iteration-documentation.md                                        |
| S17 | Deliverables projected from governed artifacts, every number sourced, gated and inspected                                             | workflows/modes/present.md, workflows/activities/06-iterate/artifacts/deliverable/meta.yml              |
| S18 | Targets: < 3 findings per run; 3 runtimes in 12 months; 50+ repos in 18 months                                                        | docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#success-definition, docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#success-metrics |
| S19 | Layers are the control: each layer governs the next; a change enters at the top layer it affects; rules live in a layer, not a prompt | workflows/principles.md#layers-are-the-control                                                          |
| S20 | The hierarchy as control loop: authority flows down, concerns cross layers, gates sit between layers, humans hold the hand-offs       | workflows/artifact-hierarchy.md#the-hierarchy-is-the-control-loop                                       |

# Sources (continued)

| Id  | Claim or figure                                                                                                                                                 | Governing artifact and section                                                                                                                  |
|-----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| S21 | Humans decide, agents draft: people own intent, judgment, approval; agents own drafting, checking, surfacing, recording; every hand-off has an owner and a rule | <a href="#">workflows/principles.md#humans-decide-agents-draft</a>                                                                              |
| S22 | Hand-off table: approval, autonomy level, stop triggers, escalation, surfaced judgment, and the rule behind each                                                | <a href="#">workflows/README.md#human-ai-collaboration</a> ,<br><a href="#">docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#key-value-propositions</a> |